Ramakrishna Mission, going back to the 1900s. It even has colonial documents dating back to 1785, such as William Chambers's *A History of the Marratta State*, published in 1787, and *A History of English Education in India* (1895) by Syed Mahmood.[81] All of these documents have been digitised, catalogued and cross-referenced, using library digitisation and cataloguing techniques that mirror the professional techniques used by academic libraries globally. As the digital archive of a political party in India, it is certainly unrivalled.

Moreover, each party state unit was asked to create a history of its own unit by collecting old documents, talking to older cadres and archiving these records. The BJP's Anirban Ganguly and Shiwanand Dwivedi have documented a revealing conversation Shah had with the Madhya Pradesh party unit's library and documentation department during a review meeting, which illustrates the importance of this history project for the party. 'Did the *Ram Janmabhoomi* movement take place?' Shah asked. When the department members said yes, he asked, 'how many documents relating to the *Ram Janmabhoomi* movement are available in the state office? If somebody requires some information related to *Ram Janmabhoomi* movement right now, what documents do we have in the office at this point of time?'[82] Then Shah explained his reasons for investing in such archives. They were meant to document the lives of the party's eminent leaders for its workers. Crucially, they also aimed to provide an alternative view of history—one from the party's ideological standpoint—for global researchers. The project aims at nothing less than writing a new political history of India. As Shah told party workers in Bhopal, 'With the kind of changes that the country is undergoing at this moment, researchers from around the world would be gradually approaching us with great interest to know more about the Bharatiya Janata Party in the next fifteen to twenty years. But if we do not have records, then what will we give them? Are we only going to tell them that here is a table, this is a room, that is a chair and we have provision for food here…? We must do our documentation as if we are preparing to write the entire political history of India in 2021.'[83]

This theme of encouraging research on the party is one that Prime Minister Modi too often returns to. In May 2019, at a press